

INTRODUCTION

In the Global North, the conversation about AI is about overuse — "brain rot," addiction, displacement.

In the Global South, the conversation is about absence.

2.6 billion people offline in 2024.

Africa: effectively 0 large-scale AI systems.

The AI that rots minds in the North is not the AI that could transform a Rwandan classroom. One is consumption. The other is leverage.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- 1. To what extent does AI access shape educational outcomes in Rwanda compared to the Global North?
- 2. Which policy instruments determine who gets access to frontier AI?
- 3. Can a Global-South-led strategy realistically close the gap, or does meaningful access depend on cooperation with the Global North?

METHODOLOGY

- 1. Single-country case study (Rwanda); comparative framing
- 2. Eight sources: peer-reviewed journals, intergovernmental and national policy, book chapter, institutional data
- 3. Two visualizations from Our World in Data (ITU; Epoch AI)
- 4. Education system as the focal sector
- 5. Secondary research only

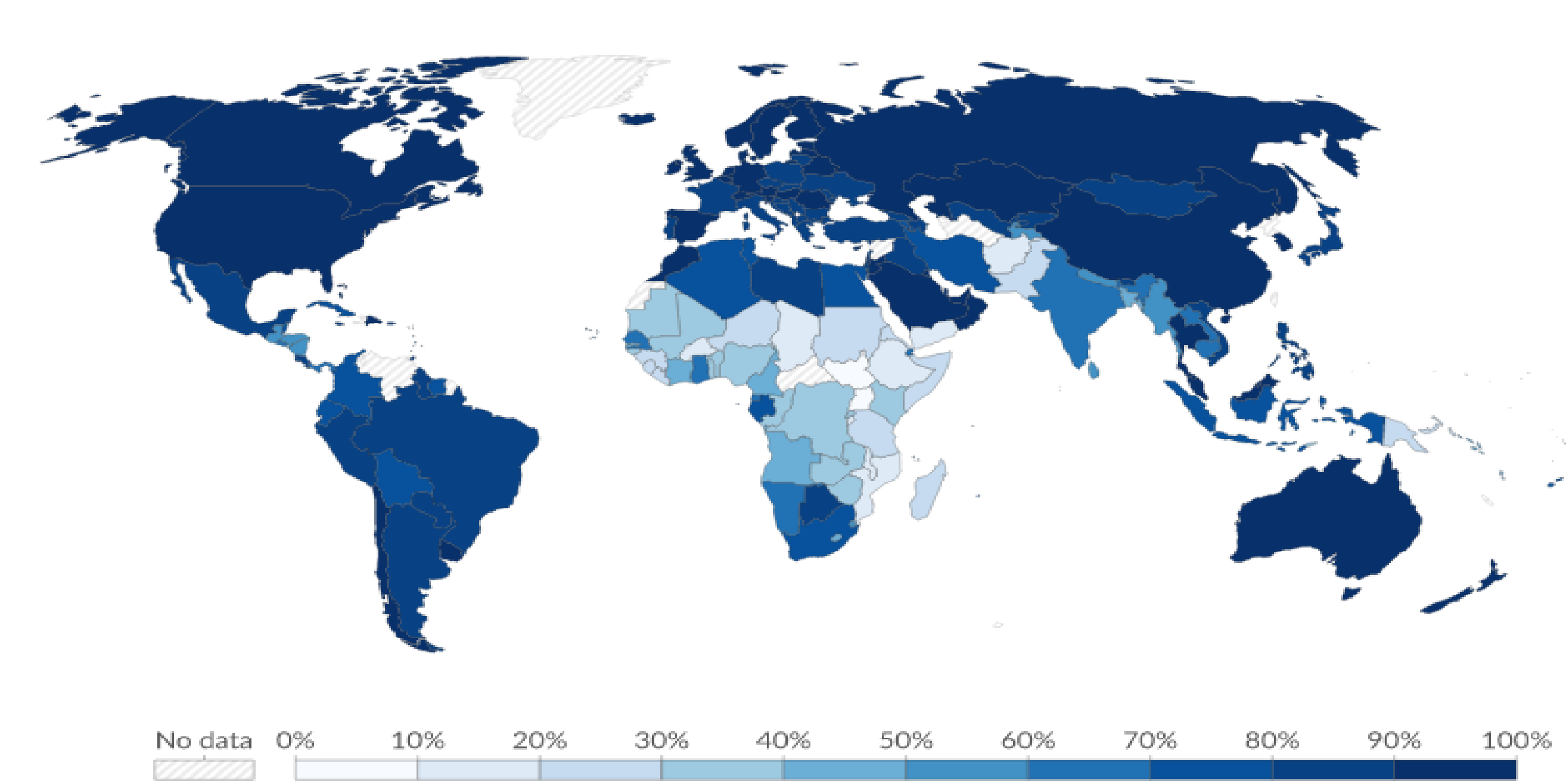
THE EVIDENCE

Access is layered

Internet penetration by income tier, 2024

Share of the population using the Internet, 2025

Share of the population who used the Internet in the last three months.



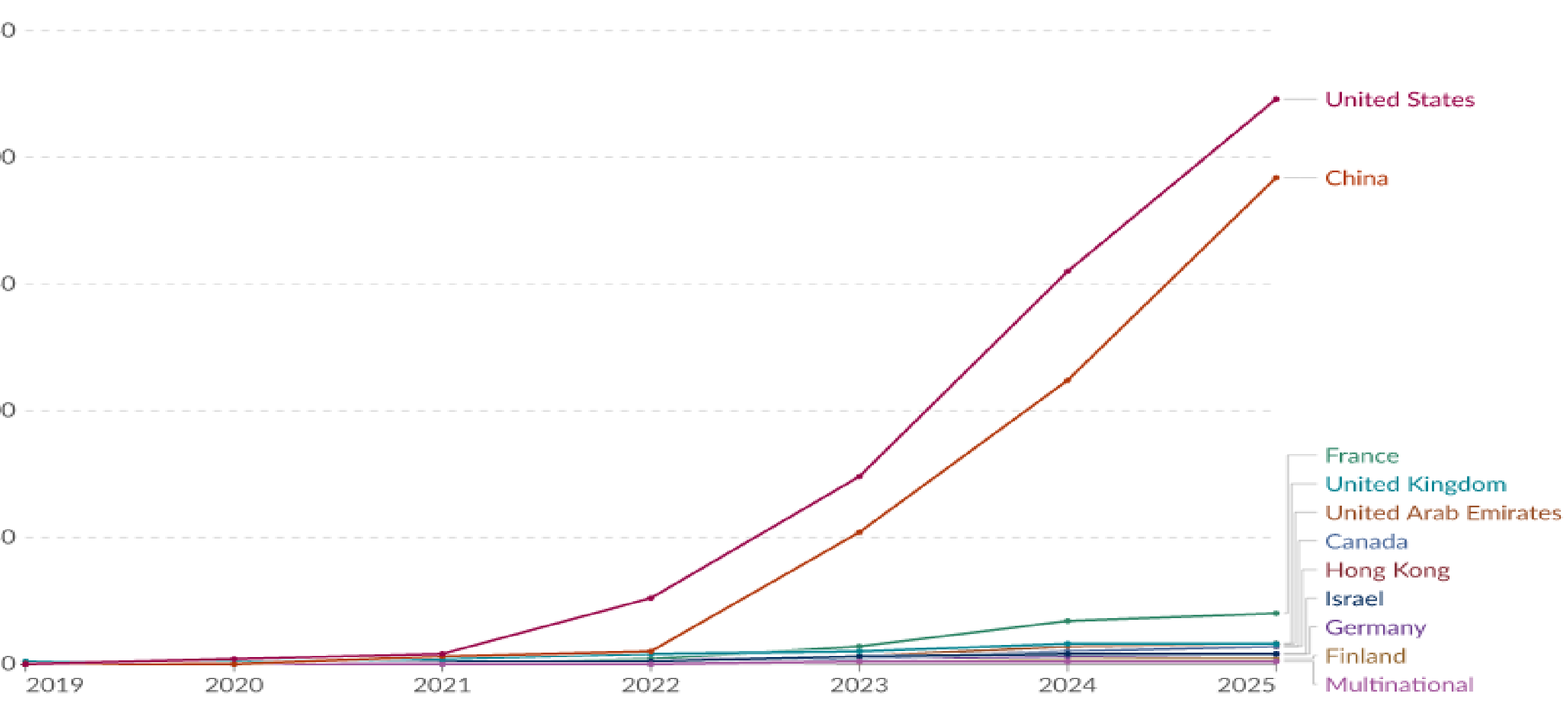
Data source: World Telecommunication/ICT Indicators Database - International Telecommunication Union (ITU), via World Bank (2026)
OurWorldinData.org/internet | CC BY

AI development is concentrated

Cumulative large-scale AI systems by country, 2019–2025

Cumulative number of large-scale AI systems by country since 2019

Refers to the location of the primary organization with which the authors of a large-scale AI systems are affiliated.



Data source: Epoch AI (2026)
OurWorldinData.org/artificial-intelligence | CC BY
Note: The source defines AI models as "large-scale" when their training compute is confirmed to exceed 10²³ floating-point operations.

Rwanda's tools meet a stacked deficit

The access gap compounds at every level of the education system

274,073

XO laptops distributed via OLPC since 2008. Hardware-first; learning gains uneven without trained teachers, electricity, and curriculum.

English-as-instruction since 2008

while Kinyarwanda remains the home language. AI tutoring tools arrive in a second language.

CMU-Africa Kigali + AIMS Rwanda

train Rwandan AI talent, but compute and funding depend on Global-North partners (Mastercard Foundation, Gov. of Canada).

Kinyarwanda is low-resource

in mainstream AI models. Birhane (2021): the absence is structural — not a bug to be patched.

AI access is a human-rights issue, not a development question.

Closing the gap requires neither pure sovereignty nor passive cooperation.

HYBRID MODEL: Global-South-led strategy. Global-North cooperation. **Terms set by the Global South.**

SUPPORT

1. Sovereignty alone is blocked.

Crawford (2021): "AI is neither artificial nor intelligent... it is both embodied and material, made from natural resources, fuel, human labor, infrastructures" (p. 8). These inputs are concentrated in the Global North. Rwanda cannot build a frontier-training stack from scratch in the short term.

2. Cooperation alone is dependency.

Birhane (2021) cautions that projects framed as "AI for Africa" can replicate extractive patterns rather than reduce them when the terms of partnership are set by Global-North actors. The hybrid model only works if Global-South parties set the terms.

3. The scaffolding already exists.

Mohamed, Png & Isaac (2020) name this dynamic algorithmic coloniality and propose decolonial methods. MINICT's National AI Policy (2023) is the first move. UNESCO's Recommendation (2021) gives the legal frame. The African Union's Continental AI Strategy (2024) provides regional coordination.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Students

Ask your university whether its AI procurement requires open-weight options or low-resource language support. Most do not. Support student orgs advocating for AI access in your country of origin.

Researchers

Contribute to Kinyarwanda and other low-resource language data sets through community-curated platforms. Cite Global-South AI scholars by name: Birhane, Ricaurte, Oyedemi, Mohamed.

Tech & Policy

Demand UNESCO Recommendation implementation reports from your government. Advocate for export-control regimes that include human-rights review. Push for open weights, regional pricing, and multilingual models.

Follow & contact

UNESCO AI Ethics Observatory
AU Continental AI Strategy desk
MINICT — minict.gov.rw
Mozilla Foundation (open weights)